

The Development of Speciesism Across Culture

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Introduction

- Animals are valued less than humans. But is this true across cultures, across age groups, and across animal species?
- Speciesism refers to the assignment of different inherent moral status based solely on an individual's species membership
- Here, we examine the developmental trajectory of speciesism and its behavioral correlates across childhood, adolescence, and adulthood, using participants from diverse cultural settings

Key Questions

- Within each country, what is the shape of the developmental trajectory in *[speciesism, moral status attribution, eating animals' evaluation]*
- Using pre-registered age bins (children < 12, adolescents 12-17, adults 18+), do children, adolescents and adults differ in their *[speciesism, moral status attribution, eating animals' evaluation]*
- Within each country, what is the developmental window of greatest change in *[speciesism, moral status attribution, eating animals' evaluation]*

Methods

- The final sample included 2035 participants from 8- to 22-years-old, from China, Germany, South Korea, Türkiye, and the United Kingdom
- Models were fit via Bayesian inference using Hamiltonian Markov Chain Monte Carlo using the *r* package *brms*
- Data were analyzed using Bayesian hierarchical generalized additive models, a data driven statistical method to explore non-linear processes whereby the shape of the function can vary by different grouping levels
- Cumulative logit link functions were fit for ordinal responses, logit link functions were fit for binary responses
- To answer all research questions, posterior predictions were generated from the fitted Bayesian models. The covariates: diet, gender, religious identity, and animal guardianship were controlled for

Results Across 5 sites, there was evidence that in general...

Speciesism

(a) with increasing age, speciesism increased, (b) children had lower speciesism compared to adolescents and adults, and (c) the developmental window of greatest change occurs between childhood and adolescence.

Ascription of Moral Status to Different Species

(a) with age, the moral status attributed to animal species decreased, b) depending on the categorisation or role an animal plays in a culture, there was evidence of culturally dependent downgrading, c) while participants of all ages showed evidence of forming a moral status hierarchy, children were less likely to report such a stark difference between other animals and humans, whereas adults devalued other animals relative to humans

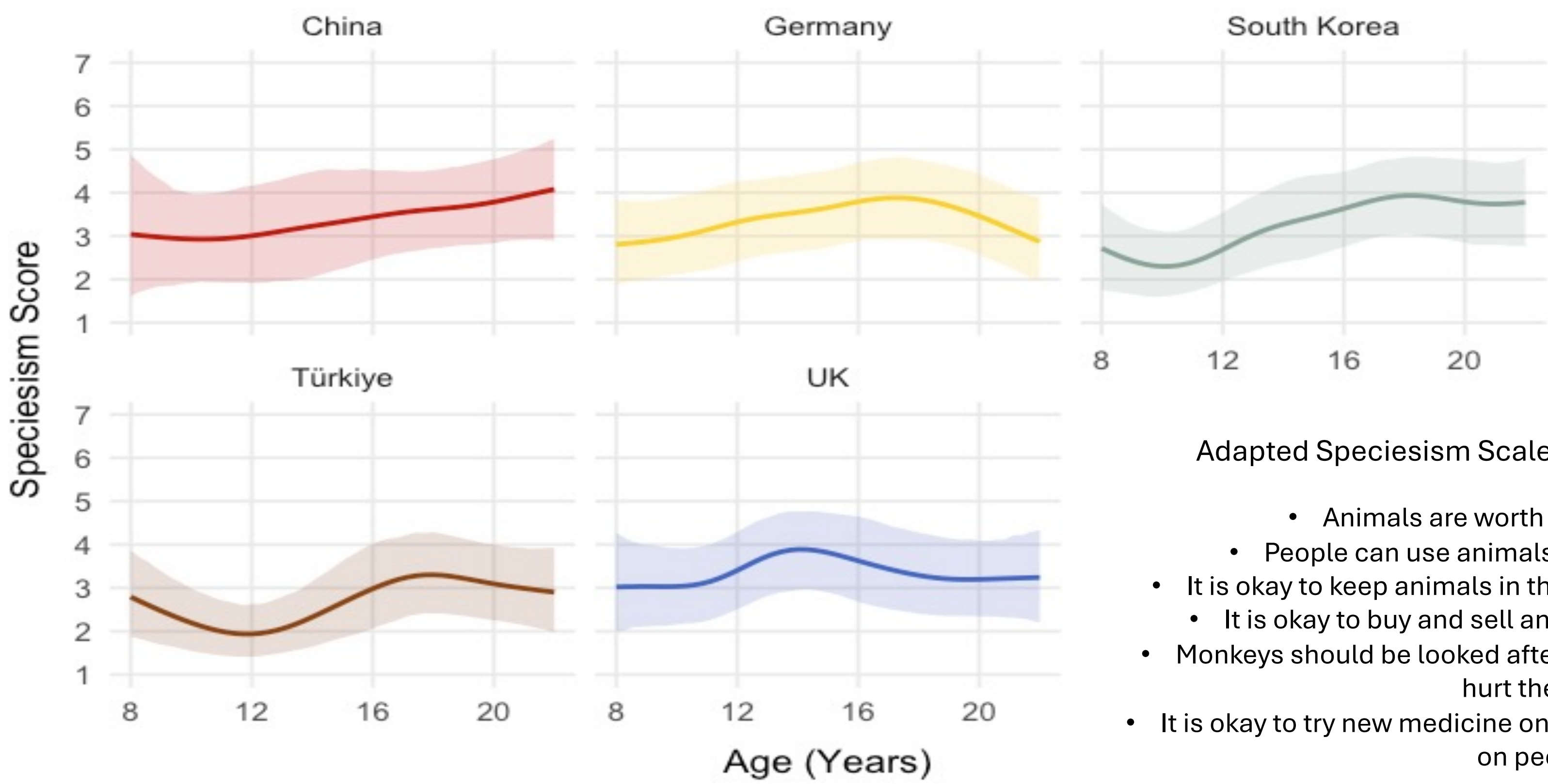
Moral Evaluation of Eating Animals

(a) with increasing age, evaluation of the moral acceptability of eating animals increased, (b) children, compared to adolescents and adults, evaluated eating animals as less morally acceptable and (c) the developmental window of greatest change occurs between childhood and adolescence.

Discussion

- Findings highlight the scope and pervasive nature of speciesism, with evidence of remarkable similarity in the cross-cultural, developmental trajectories of moral attitudes regarding animals
- We argue speciesism is an increasingly prominent feature of human cognition and behaviour, with the specific expression of speciesist attitudes and behaviour likely to be a product of cultural socialisation
- Project provides evidence of age-related differences in our moral view of animals that point to socially constructed development

Speciesism Scale

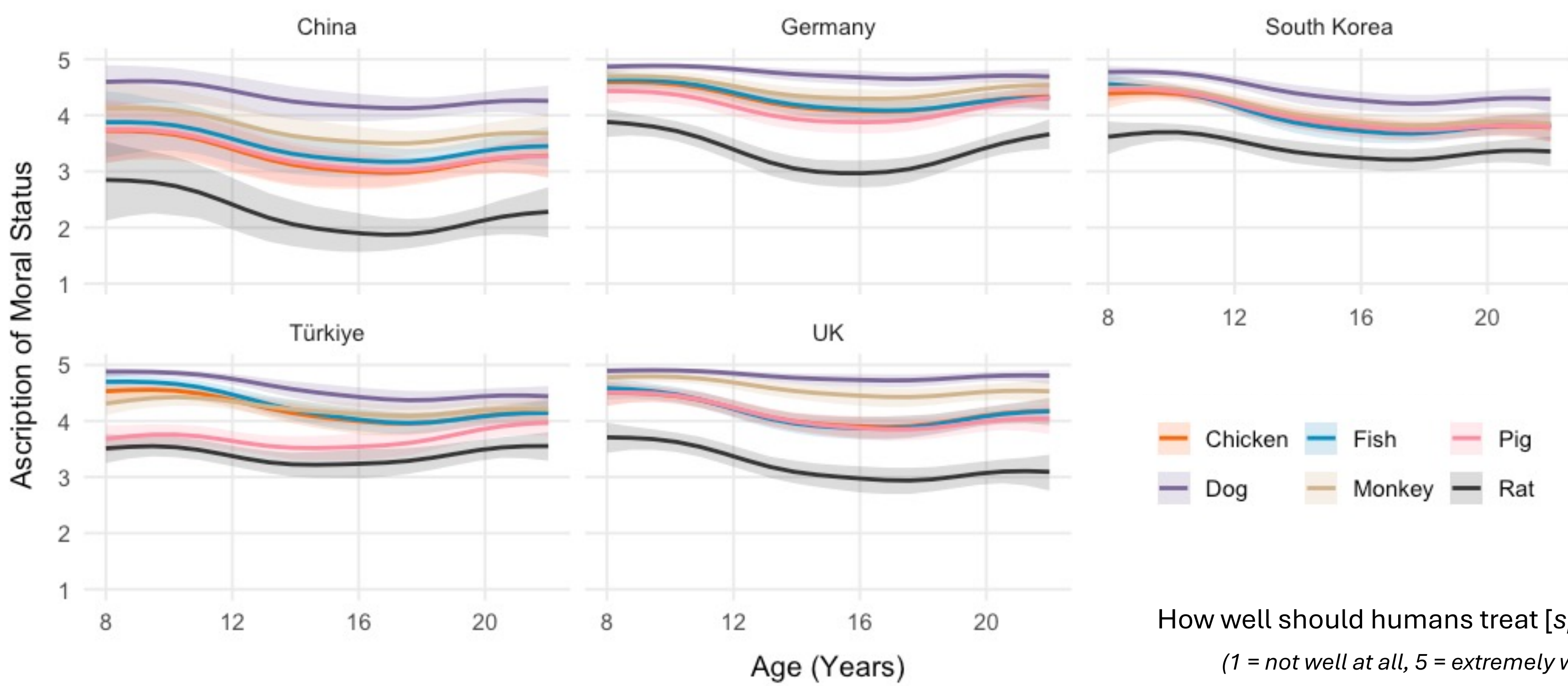


Adapted Speciesism Scale (McGuire et al., 2023)

- Animals are worth less than people
- People can use animals in any way they want
- It is okay to keep animals in the circus for people to watch
- It is okay to buy and sell animals like toys or clothes
- Monkeys should be looked after so people aren't allowed to hurt them (r)
- It is okay to try new medicine on animals that we would not try on people

(1 = no definitely not, 7 = yes, definitely)

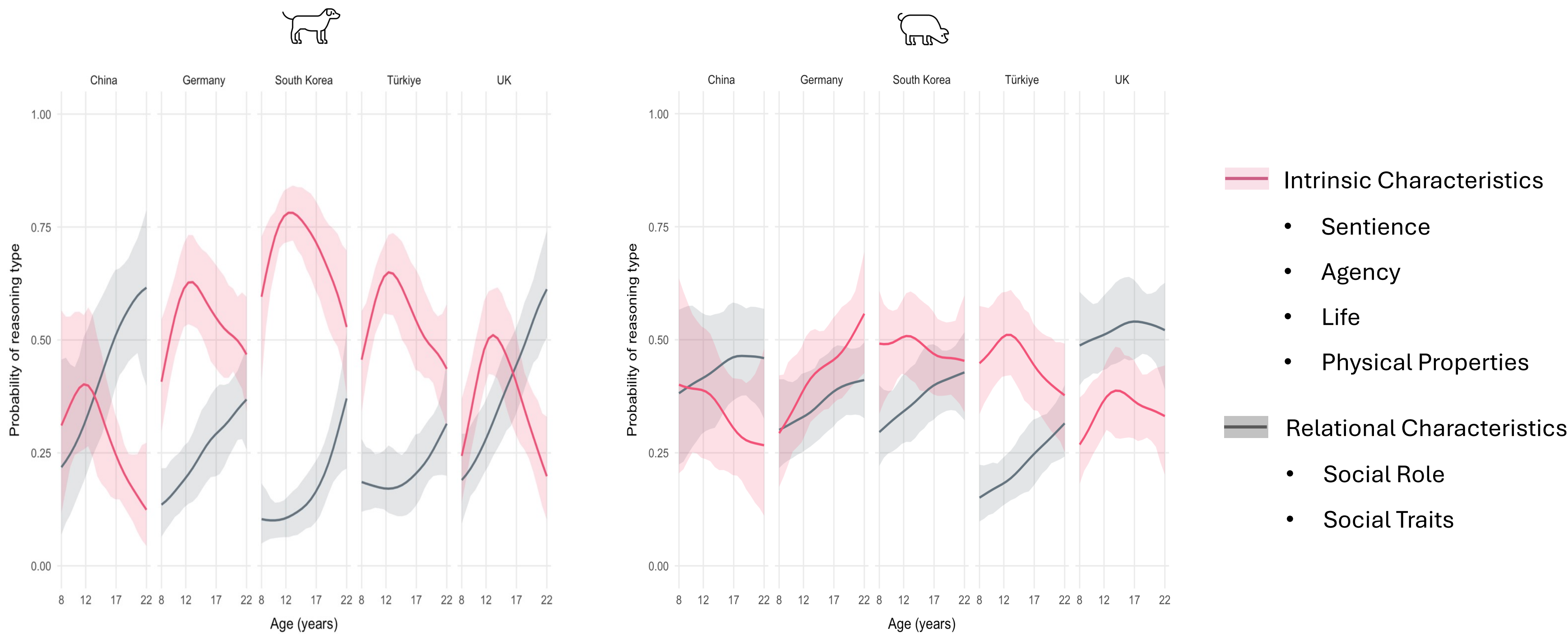
Ascription of Moral Status to Species



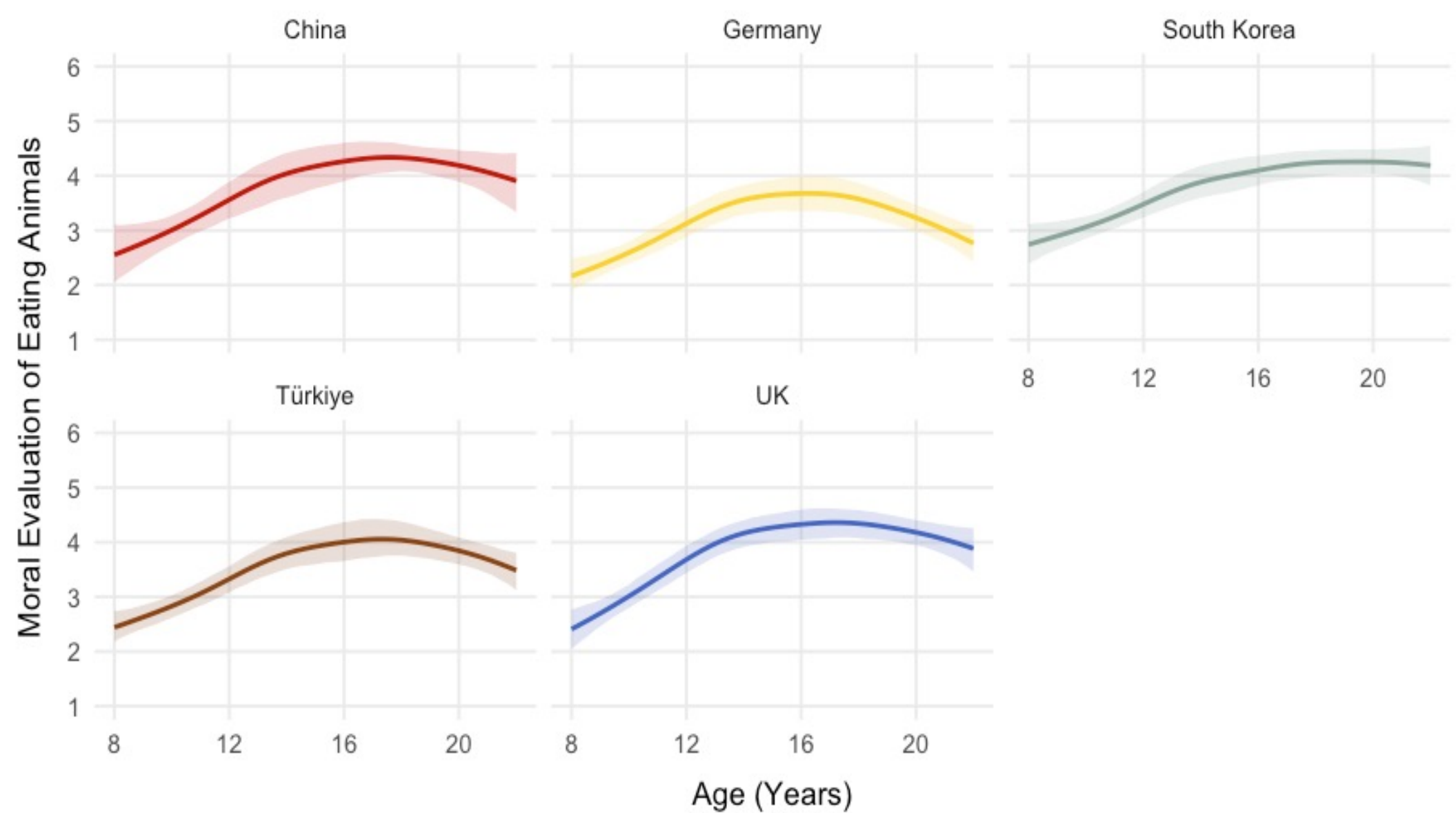
How well should humans treat [species]?

(1 = not well at all, 5 = extremely well)

Reasoning for Moral Status Ascription



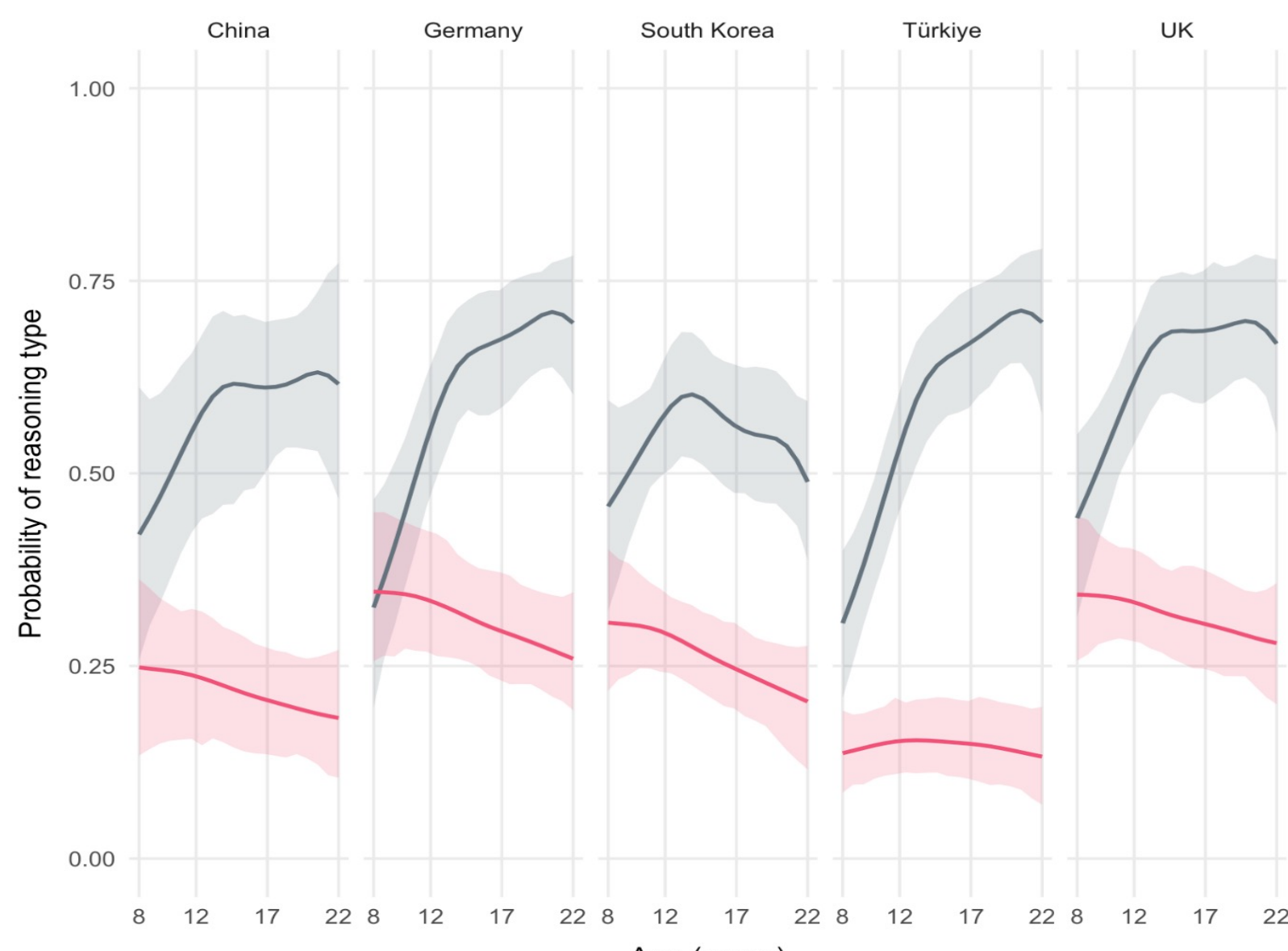
Moral Evaluation of Eating Animals



“How okay or not okay is it to eat animals?”

1 = really not okay, 6 = really okay

Reasoning for Eating Evaluation



Moral

Animal Rights Animal Welfare

4 N's

Natural Normal Necessary Nice